



# GCMWC

GLOBAL COMMISSION FOR MENTAL WELLNESS COACHING

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# PROGRAM STANDARDS MANUAL

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PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS, SCOPE OF PRACTICE,  
ETHICS, AND CREDENTIALING FRAMEWORK

# GCMWC PROGRAM STANDARDS MANUAL

## PUBLIC DOWNLOAD VERSION

### IMPORTANT NOTICE

GCMWC credentials do not constitute licensure, psychotherapy certification, medical authorization, or permission to diagnose, treat, or manage mental health conditions. Mental Wellness Coaching is a non-clinical discipline. Credential holders must comply with all applicable laws and professional requirements in the jurisdictions where they practice.

This manual is designed for students, credential holders, training partners, institutions, churches, wellness organizations, and members of the public who want to understand how GCMWC defines Mental Wellness Coaching and protects the boundary between coaching and clinical care.

### How to Use This Manual

- Prospective students should review the scope, ethics, and credential requirements before enrolling.
- Credential holders should use this manual as a practice boundary guide and renewal reference.
- Institutions and partner schools should use this manual to understand curriculum expectations and professional standards.
- Clients and the public should use this manual to understand what Mental Wellness Coaches can and cannot provide.

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# 1. INTRODUCTION TO GCMWC

The Global Commission for Mental Wellness Coaching exists to bring structure, clarity, and accountability to the field of Mental Wellness Coaching.

Mental wellness coaching is growing because many people need practical, non-clinical support for stress, identity, behavior patterns, burnout, emotional regulation, wellness routines, spiritual development, and life transitions. That growth creates a responsibility. Coaches need standards. Clients need protection. Institutions need a clear framework. The public needs to know the difference between coaching and treatment.

GCMWC provides a standards-based framework for training, credentialing, ethical practice, renewal, and discipline. The goal is to prepare coaches who can support people responsibly while knowing exactly when to refer to licensed professionals.

## CORE POSITION

Mental Wellness Coaching supports growth, self-awareness, wellness planning, and behavior change. It does not diagnose, treat, or manage mental health disorders.

# 2. PURPOSE AND AUTHORITY

GCMWC functions as an independent standards-setting and credentialing body for non-clinical Mental Wellness Coaching. Its role is to define professional expectations, establish training benchmarks, uphold ethical conduct, and create a clear framework for credential holders.

The Commission may establish program standards, review credential eligibility, issue credentials, revoke credentials, investigate complaints, enforce ethics requirements, and maintain public trust in the coaching profession.

| STANDARD AREA        | WHAT GCMWC DEFINES                                                                    |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Training Standards   | Minimum education, curriculum, practice, assessment, and completion expectations.     |
| Scope Boundaries     | What Mental Wellness Coaches may do, may not do, and when referral is required.       |
| Credential Integrity | Eligibility, designation rules, renewal expectations, and good standing requirements. |
| Ethics Enforcement   | Complaint review, remediation, suspension, and revocation procedures.                 |
| Institutional Use    | Expectations for schools or organizations adopting GCMWC curriculum.                  |

### 3. DEFINITIONS

| TERM                        | DEFINITION                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mental Wellness Coaching    | A non-clinical coaching discipline that supports mental, emotional, physical, and spiritual wellness through education, reflection, goal-setting, accountability, and practical behavior change. |
| Credential Holder           | An individual who has met GCMWC training, assessment, ethics, and credentialing requirements and remains in good standing.                                                                       |
| Non-Clinical Scope          | A scope of practice that does not include diagnosis, treatment, psychotherapy, crisis intervention, or medical management.                                                                       |
| Referral                    | The process of directing a client to a licensed professional or emergency resource when their needs exceed the coaching scope.                                                                   |
| Practical Skills Assessment | A structured evaluation of a student or credential applicant performing coaching skills according to a rubric.                                                                                   |
| Good Standing               | Active status that requires ethical compliance, renewal completion, and absence of unresolved disciplinary restrictions.                                                                         |

## 4. SCOPE OF PRACTICE

Scope is the boundary that protects the client, the coach, and the profession.

Mental Wellness Coaching is a non-clinical, non-diagnostic discipline. Coaches may support clients through education, reflection, goal-setting, accountability, emotional awareness, and wellness planning. Coaches may not diagnose mental health disorders, provide psychotherapy, manage crisis care, or replace licensed medical or behavioral health providers.

### GREEN ZONE: WITHIN SCOPE

- Educate clients on stress, resilience, emotional regulation, and wellness principles.
- Facilitate structured conversations that support self-awareness, growth, and behavior change.
- Help clients identify goals, patterns, obstacles, and practical action steps.
- Provide accountability around wellness routines, boundaries, habits, and personal development.
- Use non-clinical tools such as reflective questions, journaling prompts, values clarification, grounding skills, and goal-setting frameworks.
- Support clients in developing mental, emotional, physical, and spiritual wellness plans.
- Encourage appropriate referrals when a client's needs exceed the coaching scope.

### RED ZONE: OUTSIDE SCOPE

- Diagnose mental health disorders using DSM, ICD, or clinical criteria.
- Treat depression, anxiety disorders, trauma, bipolar disorder, psychosis, substance use disorder, or other clinical conditions.
- Provide psychotherapy, trauma processing, crisis intervention, or clinical counseling.
- Create or manage medication, supplement, or treatment plans.
- Replace a licensed therapist, psychiatrist, nurse practitioner, physician, or other medical provider.
- Manage active suicidal ideation, homicidal ideation, psychosis, abuse, domestic violence, severe addiction, or acute psychiatric instability.
- Present themselves as licensed clinicians unless they separately hold an active professional license and are practicing within that license.

## 5. REFERRAL AND PUBLIC SAFETY STANDARDS

Referral is not a failure of coaching. It is part of ethical coaching. A coach must recognize when a client's needs require clinical, medical, emergency, legal, or protective intervention.

### REFERRAL IS REQUIRED WHEN A CLIENT PRESENTS WITH

Suicidal ideation  
 Homicidal ideation  
 Psychosis, hallucinations, or severe disorganization  
 Active addiction preventing meaningful engagement  
 Severe depression or functional decline  
 Domestic violence, abuse, neglect, or exploitation  
 Eating disorder symptoms

Unmanaged trauma responses that require clinical processing  
 Medical instability  
 Need for diagnosis, treatment, medication management, or crisis intervention

1. Pause the coaching process when safety concerns appear.
2. Name the boundary clearly and calmly.
3. Encourage the client to contact a licensed professional, crisis line, emergency service, or appropriate support resource.
4. Document the referral recommendation according to GCMWC expectations and applicable law.
5. Do not continue coaching as a substitute for needed clinical care.

## 6. CREDENTIAL PATHWAYS AND DESIGNATIONS

GCMWC credentialing is designed to show a person's level of training, practice readiness, and demonstrated competence within the Mental Wellness Coaching scope.

| DESIGNATION                             | MEANING                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Trained Mental Wellness Coach (MWC-T)   | Completed GCMWC core training in non-clinical mental wellness coaching. Indicates foundational preparation in ethics, boundaries, communication skills, referral awareness, and coaching support.                                  |
| Certified Mental Wellness Coach (MWC-C) | Completed all GCMWC program requirements, including documented coaching practice and rubric-based performance evaluation. Indicates readiness to deliver structured, ethical Mental Wellness Coaching within a non-clinical scope. |
| Institutional Training Partner          | A school, organization, church, or wellness institution approved to adopt or deliver GCMWC-aligned curriculum under defined standards.                                                                                             |

### CREDENTIAL USE RULE

Credential holders must use their designation accurately. No GCMWC credential may be represented as a license, therapy certification, medical credential, or authorization to provide clinical care.

## 7. TRAINING AND CURRICULUM STANDARDS

GCMWC training is designed to prepare coaches through a whole-person framework that includes mental, emotional, physical, and spiritual wellness. The curriculum must remain practical, ethical, and clearly separated from clinical treatment.

| CURRICULUM AREA                   | REQUIRED FOCUS                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Foundations of Coaching           | Coaching roles, agreements, ethics, listening, questions, scope, and boundaries.                                  |
| Mental Wellness Frameworks        | Stress, emotional regulation, trauma-informed awareness, red flags, referral protocols, and non-clinical support. |
| Faith-Based Integration           | Ethical integration of faith, prayer, reflection, identity, forgiveness, and spiritual support without coercion.  |
| Nutrition and Emotional Health    | Education on nutrition, hydration, gut-brain connection, and referral to appropriate professionals when needed.   |
| Pharmacology Awareness            | Basic awareness of supplements, medications, referral considerations, and the limits of coaching scope.           |
| Wellness Coaching Strategies      | Behavior change, motivational interviewing, emotional intelligence, action planning, and accountability.          |
| Business and Practice Development | Contracts, ethical marketing, pricing, client management, documentation, and professional boundaries.             |
| Practical Application             | Peer coaching, observed coaching, mentor feedback, case studies, and final performance evaluation.                |

Programs adopting the GCMWC curriculum should include measurable learning outcomes, clear assessment standards, practical coaching demonstrations, documented feedback, and policies that protect students and clients.

## 8. ETHICAL PRACTICE AND PROFESSIONAL CONDUCT

GCMWC credential holders are expected to practice with integrity, humility, confidentiality, and clear professional boundaries. Ethical coaching requires honesty about scope, credentials, outcomes, fees, confidentiality limits, and referral obligations.

A coach must never use emotional vulnerability, spiritual authority, professional status, or personal influence to manipulate, pressure, exploit, or control a client.

- Represent training and credentials accurately.
- Maintain confidentiality within legal and ethical limits.
- Avoid dual relationships that create conflicts of interest.
- Use transparent fees, contracts, and coaching agreements.
- Obtain informed consent before beginning coaching.
- Stay within non-clinical scope.
- Refer clients when needs exceed coaching.
- Avoid coercive spiritual, emotional, or financial influence.
- Document services according to GCMWC expectations.



- Cooperate with any ethics review or complaint investigation.

## 9. COMPLAINTS, ENFORCEMENT, AND DISCIPLINE

GCMWC maintains an ethics and disciplinary process to protect the public and uphold the credibility of the credential. Complaints may be submitted by clients, peers, institutions, faculty, or members of the general public.

| STEP                     | PROCESS                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Complaint Received    | A formal complaint is submitted to GCMWC for review.                                                                       |
| 2. Initial Review        | The Commission determines whether the complaint falls within GCMWC authority.                                              |
| 3. Information Gathering | The credential holder may be asked to provide documentation, explanation, or corrective response.                          |
| 4. Decision              | The Commission may dismiss the complaint, issue corrective action, require remediation, suspend, or revoke the credential. |
| 5. Public Safety Action  | Immediate suspension may be imposed if there is risk of harm to clients or the public.                                     |

Possible actions may include written warning, ethics education, supervised remediation, temporary suspension, credential revocation, public status update, or referral to outside authorities when required by law.

## 10. RENEWAL AND CONTINUING EDUCATION

GCMWC credentials are not lifetime credentials. Credential holders must remain in good standing, complete continuing education, follow ethical standards, and renew within the required credential cycle.

| RENEWAL REQUIREMENT  | EXPECTATION                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Credential Cycle     | GCMWC credentials are valid for two years unless suspended or revoked.                                                                            |
| Continuing Education | Credential holders must document continuing education related to coaching, ethics, mental wellness, referral awareness, or professional practice. |
| Practice Attestation | Credential holders must attest that they are practicing within scope and following GCMWC standards.                                               |
| Ethics Compliance    | Credential holders must disclose unresolved complaints,                                                                                           |



|      |                                                                                |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|      | disciplinary actions, or relevant professional restrictions.                   |
| Fees | Credential holders must pay applicable renewal fees to maintain active status. |

## 11. LEGACY ROUTE AND GRANDPARENTING

The Legacy Route, also called grandparenting, is a time-limited pathway for experienced practitioners who were already practicing coaching, wellness support, ministry care, peer support, or related helping work before the full credentialing system was finalized.

The Legacy Route is not automatic approval. It is a structured review pathway. Applicants must provide documentation of experience, training, professional references, and must pass the official Standards and Ethics Exam.

- Documented prior experience in coaching, wellness support, ministry care, peer support, or a related helping role.
- Evidence of training, continuing education, mentorship, or supervised practice.
- Professional references or organizational verification where available.
- Agreement to follow GCMWC scope, ethics, referral, and renewal standards.
- Successful completion of the Standards and Ethics Exam.

## 12. INSTITUTIONAL ADOPTION STANDARDS

Schools, churches, nonprofits, wellness organizations, healthcare-adjacent programs, and training institutions may seek to adopt or align with the GCMWC curriculum. Institutional adoption must protect curriculum integrity and maintain the distinction between coaching and clinical care.

| INSTITUTIONAL STANDARD | REQUIREMENT                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Curriculum Integrity   | The adopted curriculum must be delivered as approved or reviewed through the GCMWC curriculum alignment process.                          |
| Qualified Instruction  | Faculty must be qualified to teach assigned content and must understand coaching scope and referral standards.                            |
| Student Protection     | Students must receive accurate information about credential meaning, scope boundaries, tuition, completion requirements, and limitations. |
| Assessment Standards   | Programs must use approved rubrics, practical coaching evaluation, case-based learning, and documented feedback.                          |
| Marketing Accuracy     | Institutions may not misrepresent GCMWC credentials as licensure, therapy certification, or clinical authorization.                       |

Compliance Cooperation

Institutions must cooperate with audits, reporting, complaints, and corrective action when applicable.

## 13. CREDENTIAL HOLDER ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Credential holders and applicants should acknowledge that they understand and agree to follow GCMWC standards. This acknowledgment may be used during enrollment, credentialing, renewal, or institutional adoption processes.

### ACKNOWLEDGMENT STATEMENT

I understand that Mental Wellness Coaching is a non-clinical discipline. I agree to practice within the GCMWC scope of practice, follow ethical standards, protect client confidentiality within legal limits, refer clients when needs exceed coaching, and represent my credential accurately. I understand that violation of these standards may result in remediation, suspension, or revocation of my credential.

Printed Name

Signature

Credential or Program

Date

# CLOSING STANDARD

**Standards protect the client. Standards protect the coach. Standards protect the profession.**

Mental Wellness Coaching sits in a sensitive space. Clients often come with stress, emotional pain, relational patterns, spiritual questions, burnout, grief, low self-worth, or major life transitions. Coaches need more than passion. They need structure, ethics, referral awareness, and discipline.

**[www.gcmwc.org](http://www.gcmwc.org) | [support@theperfectrx.com](mailto:support@theperfectrx.com) | 323-568-1700 | @gcmwc\_coaching**